cause it deals with eternal human emotions".

Pattanaik recently also authored *Bahubali: 63 Insights into Jainism* (2023). Ask him for three key takeaways from the book and he says, "The three insights are the eternal principles of Jainism. They are: *Ahimsa* which for me, in its finest essence, is contentment. *Aparigraha* in its finest form leads to generosity. *Anekantvad*, which, for me, means plurality and allowing others to have different opinions."

Divergent opinions is something Pattanaik has tackled all his life, not least on social media platforms, where he manages to retain his equanimity even when conversations get noisy. How does he do it? "Imagine yourself walking in a forest that has all kinds of trees. Some are poisonous, some are thorny, some are fragrant, and some bear fruits that are delicious. If you know where you want to go, you will walk the right path and know which trees to enjoy and which trees to avoid," he says.

Meanwhile, with the podcast released, the prolific Pattanaik is as busy as ever, with multiple book projects on the Vedas, the Puranas, the Itihasa, Buddhism as well as culture and "maybe, something specifically, on Bakasura". There are clearly many, many chapters in this tale. And it helps that he is such a goddamn good storyteller. ■

Amit Dixit

BOOKS

Maximum Drama

Lindsay Pereira's *The Memoirs of Valmiki Rao* is a modern retelling of the Ramayana set in Mumbai in the 1990s

This is the story of Ganga Niwas and Sri Niwas, two neighbouring chawls in Parel, Mumbai. Valmiki Rao, a retired postman and resident of Ganga Niwas, writes down his memories of the year the Babri Masjid fell in Ayodhya, and the riots that engulfed Mumbai in its aftermath. The running theme: "What did people in his chawl have to do with a mosque that was being attacked in a city none of them had ever seen?"

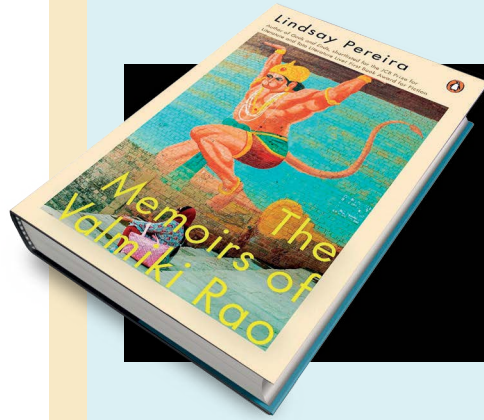
The novel has multiple strands. It chronicles the rise of the Shiv Sena, and the opportunistic alliances it struck with the Bajrang Dal and the VHP. In the middle of the 1980s, festivals like Gokulashtami "started to get bigger.... That is when politicians and Shiv Sena leaders began transforming them with money". In 1984, the Bajrang Dal appears on the scene. By 1992, new slogans like 'Jai Shri Ram' and 'Chalo Ayodhya' enter the chawls' vocabulary: "They wanted a temple for their God even though none of them bothered visiting the same God in Parel." This part is about the nationalisation of Lord Ram, one amongst many gods in the Hindu pantheon. The book works well as a complex potted history of the rise of the Hindu Right in Mumbai. We are told how older Sena shakhas have "embrasures—little openings through which cannons can be fired", while the new ones sport "bright orange walls set against brass-coloured doors and blue-tinted windows".

The second strand is a tragic love story, which involves characters from both chawls: Surbha is fixated on Ramu, who is in love with Janaki, whom Ravi Anna desires. But wait, this perturbed novel is also a tedious retelling of the Ramayana, and so Ramu mirrors Ram, Janaki is Sita, and so on.

The big idea underpinning the novel is fine as a conceit; it works as cannon fodder for Eng Lit academics. What the lay reader is interested in is, simply, how the story is told. The answer is: badly. *The Memoirs of Valmiki Rao* comes across as a confused mix of tautological interior monologue about the poverty of circumstance and manipulative politicians; and straight-on Atlee-like action: "He was trying to speak, which only pushed the blood out in bigger spurts and a bubble of red-speckled saliva started to form...". In short, Rajinikanth meets Govind Nihalani.

There are clichés aplenty: in a chawl, we see "broken dreams in every corner"; "In Mumbai, we are all survivors". There is lazy repetition: "bookstores in shiny malls" on page xxiii of the Prologue, is followed by "malls filled with shiny things" on page 16. On page 203, Ravi and Ramu "both toppled to the floor", and again on page 208, Ravi runs headfirst into Ramu, "toppling him". The metaphors are tired: "Urgency thrummed in the air like electricity", and silence "descends like a heavy cloak". There is the occasional bright spot. Boys collapsing on each other while trying to break the matka "was like a chapatti folding into itself after being removed from a hot pan, the air escaping in a puff". ■

Palash Krishna Mehrotra



THE MEMOIRS OF VALMIKI RAO
By Lindsay Pereira
PENGUIN VINTAGE
₹599; 320 pages

The novel focuses on the rise of the Hindu Right in Mumbai, particularly the Shiv Sena and its alliances with the Bajrang Dal and the VHP